



THE ENDGAME

IAEA CLEARANCE: After winning the vote of confidence in Parliament, the Government would request the International Atomic Energy Agency (IAEA) Board to clear India-specific safeguards that were under negotiations. At the earliest this could be done by July 28.

NUCLEAR SUPPLIERS GROUP: Once the IAEA clearance is in, the US would ask for a special meeting of the NSG and ask it to make an exception to permit its 45 members to engage in civilian nuclear trade with India. The NSG clearance to do so is expected to happen by September.

US CONGRESS RATIFICATION: After US President George Bush makes a determination that India has fulfilled its side of the deal, he would send it to the US Congress for ratification. The current US Congress term ends in January 2009 and it may leave it to the incoming one to endorse it.

“IT’S STILL A DEAL”

“I respect the prime minister and India a lot. It’s very important that the US continues to develop the strategic relationship with India.”

GEORGE BUSH, US President

“India and the US must stand tall, stand shoulder to shoulder on key issues. Our relationship has never been in such good shape as now.”

MANMOHAN SINGH, Prime Minister

BACK IN BUSINESS: Manmohan and Bush at the G8 Summit

would go all out to move the deal through the remaining hoops.

The IAEA safeguards agreement would be the Government’s first big step in the last mile of the deal. It is necessary because under the Indo-US deal, India has agreed to separate its civilian nuclear reactors from those it has devoted to military weapons. The reactors it designated as civilian would in a

MANMOHAN GOING to the G8 Summit helped India canvass support for the last mile with not only George Bush but with other nuclear supplier countries.

phased manner be brought under IAEA safeguards. This means that India would establish a system of accountability for all nuclear material being used in these plants and ensure that these are not diverted for military use. IAEA inspectors would be given access to the plants and documents to find out if India was keeping its pledge. Those reactors that India designates for military use would be free from such restrictions and no IAEA personnel or inspection would be allowed in such plants. So India-specific safeguards have to be drawn up with the IAEA to agree to this unusual arrangement. It would also set the terms and conditions under which India would be allowed to conduct civilian nuclear trade with other NSG countries.

In the UPA-Left confabulations over the nuclear deal, the Left parties wanted the IAEA safeguards to have a clause ensuring that supply of fuel to Indian reactors, designated as civilian, would be guaranteed. They also wanted some escape mechanism in case these commitments were not fulfilled. It was meant to protect India’s nuclear plants from being subject to punitive sanctions including cutting off of fuel supply in case America or other